



ALTADENA'S La Vina community lost 52 homes and suffered damage to communal spaces in the Eaton fire.

Pay up quick, an HOA tells fire victims

Altadena owners clash over \$23,614 bill, with a 34-day deadline, after homes burned.

By Jack Flemming

All things considered, La Vina's fire recovery is going fairly well.

The luxury community on the northwest tip of Altadena lost 52 of its 272 homes in the Eaton fire last year, but more than 70% are currently being rebuilt, and repairs to communal spaces are well underway.

But behind closed gates, a battle has been brewing over a hefty homeowners association bill residents were forced to pay in the summer to repair damage caused by the fire.

The \$23,614 "special assessment" — forced upon every homeowner in the community — pitted neighbor against neighbor, leading to a mini civil war. Epithets were hurled, threats were levied, emergency Zoom meetings were called.

For the faction that took umbrage with the fee, it wasn't so much the amount, but the context surrounding it. The HOA announced the bill on July 29, and gave residents until Sept. 1 — 34 days — to pay it. If they didn't cough up the money, they were subjected to a deluge of late fees, 12% annual interest, and eventually, a lien on their home whether it was still standing or not.

In March, the HOA followed through on its threat. It filed a lawsuit against a resident whose house burned down, seeking a lien and foreclosure on their empty lot in order to pay off debts owed to the association, including the unpaid special assessment.

Neither the HOA board, nor its attorneys, nor its management company responded to multiple requests for comment.

"It's trouble in paradise," resident Ryan Harmon said. Harmon has emerged as the de facto leader of the resistance to the fee, vocalizing his dissent in the Google group that residents used as a message board.

It's a role that cost him dearly. Harmon — whose house was damaged by smoke, forcing him to live in a rental since the fire — said he was labeled as a troublemaker for asking questions. His next-door neighbor stopped talking to him when she found out he didn't plan to pay.

"I've created enemies," he said. "It's sad to see a once-thriving community turned so nasty. The fire [See HOA, A8]

USC cancels its governor debate amid wide uproar

The university faced criticism over criteria that would have kept candidates of color off the stage

By Seema Mehta and Nicole Nixon

USC canceled its planned Tuesday gubernatorial debate, a stunning about-face that came after days of fiery criticism about excluding every prominent candidate of color from participating.

Although the university defended the methodology used to determine who was invited to participate in the forum, it called off the event less than 24 hours before it was to take place.

In a statement late Monday night, the university

said it recognized concerns about the selection criteria had "created a significant distraction from the issues that matter to voters." The university said it discussed potentially expanding the field with debate co-sponsor KABC-TV Los Angeles but was unable to reach an agreement.

USC said that it was a "difficult decision" to cancel the debate, and that the university "will look for other opportunities to educate voters on the candidates and issues."

Former U.S. Health and Human Services Secretary Xavier Becerra, former Los

Angeles Mayor Antonio Villaraigosa, state Supt. of Public Instruction Tony Thurmond and former state Controller Betty Yee — all Democrats — had been excluded from the original debate field.

USC had faced increasing criticism in recent days, including from the four prominent candidates of color who were excluded from the gathering as they called on their fellow Democrats to boycott the forum.

"We fought. We won! We stood up against an unfair candidate debate set-up that prematurely chose win- [See Debate, A6]

LAUSD to drop Chávez name, image

Decision, spurred by sex abuse allegations, will affect two schools and multiple murals.

By Howard Blume

Los Angeles schools named after César Chávez will be renamed and his image will be removed from campus murals, the school board unanimously decided Tuesday.

The action came after a brief but emotional discussion as board members reacted to the fall of a personal and public idol who has been

a substantial presence in the nation's second-largest school district, which is 74% Latino.

Two campuses are named after him, multiple school murals bear his image, and lessons about his legacy have been taught at every grade level in the Los Angeles Unified School District.

The swift action came in the wake of allegations of sexual abuse revealed in a New York Times investigative article last week, including accusations that the late labor leader raped farmworkers' movement co-leader Dolores Huerta and sexually abused two minor

girls.

The board vote represents a significant move by yet another public agency — this one educating close to 400,000 students — to remove Chávez's name from public places.

Los Angeles educators were also directed to immediately shift from lionizing Chávez to honoring instead the farmworkers' movement. The resolution itself singles out for praise, by name, the accusers who have come forward.

School board members Kelly Gonez and Rocio Rivas — who two weeks ago won unanimous board approval for a resolution calling

Trump says Iran is negotiating, as strikes continue

Tehran denies talks as Pakistan offers to host dialogue amid murky diplomatic messaging.

By Ana Ceballos and Gavin J. Quinton

WASHINGTON — President Trump said Tuesday that Iran wants to "make a deal" with the United States to end the war in the Middle East, saying that negotiations are ongoing with the conflict in its fourth week.

Iran has publicly denied that talks are happening. But Trump told reporters during an Oval Office event that negotiations are underway and being led by Vice President JD Vance and Secretary of State Marco Rubio.

"I'd like to think we are in a good bargaining position," Trump said.

Trump said he remains skeptical of Tehran's intentions, saying he doesn't necessarily "trust them," but indicated that he is encouraged to continue talks after receiving what he described as a "very big present worth a tremendous amount of money" from Iran.

"I am not going to tell you what the present is," Trump told reporters. But he said it was a "significant prize" related to "oil and gas" that signaled to him that he was "dealing with the right people."

Conflicting messages over the diplomatic efforts between Washington and Tehran come as Pakistan has offered to host peace talks in Islamabad aimed at ending the hostilities, which have killed more than 2,400 people, further destabilized the Middle East and disrupted global oil markets.

"Pakistan welcomes and fully supports ongoing efforts to pursue dialogue to end the WAR in Middle East, in the interest of peace and stability in [the] region and beyond," Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif wrote on X.

Any potential talks between the United States and Iran would face significant challenges. Key U.S. demands — particularly related to Iran's ballistic missile and nuclear programs — remain difficult to resolve, even though Trump claims Iran has already agreed to concessions related to its ability to have nuclear weapons.

[See Iran, A4]



ILIA YEFIMOVICH AFP/Getty Images

ISRAELI soldiers check Tuesday on an Iranian missile remnant that landed in the occupied West Bank.

Justices weigh asylum policy

Court seems split on whether migrants who have not crossed into U.S. can ask for refuge.

By David G. Savage

WASHINGTON — The Trump administration urged the Supreme Court on Tuesday to rule that it may block migrants from applying for asylum at ports of entry along the southern border.

The administration's lawyers argued that the right to asylum, which arose in response to Nazi Germany and the Holocaust, does not extend to those who are stopped just short of a border post in California, Arizona or Texas.

They pointed to part of the immigration law that says a noncitizen who "arrives in the United States ... may apply for asylum."

"You can't arrive in the United States while you're still standing in Mexico. That should be the end of this case," Vivek Suri, a Justice Department attorney, told the court.

Immigration rights advocates called this claim "perverse" and illogical. They said such a rule would encourage migrants to cross the border illegally rather than present themselves legally at a border post.

The justices sounded divided and a bit uncertain over how to proceed. But the conservative majority is nonetheless likely to uphold the administration's broad [See Asylum, A6]

Bad time to job hunt, most workers report

Americans' outlook on employment is now more pessimistic, Gallup survey finds.

By Christopher Rugaber

Americans' outlook on the job market has turned increasingly pessimistic, a surprisingly negative shift given the low unemployment rate but one that probably reflects an ongoing hiring drought.

Just 28% of workers in a quarterly Gallup survey conducted late last year said now is a "good time" to find a quality job, with 72% saying it is a bad time. Those figures are a sharp reversal from just a few years ago, in mid-2022, when 70% said it was a good time.

Americans have quickly become more pessimistic: As recently as late 2024, just

under half of workers still said it was a good time to search for a job. The latest survey was conducted during the final three months of 2025, long before the Iran war that has sent oil and gas prices soaring and threatens to slow the economy as Americans redirect more of their dollars to filling gas tanks and away from other spending.

The figures help explain other surveys that show Americans have a largely bleak view of the economy, even as many headline measures suggest it has been growing and job losses are low.

College grads are especially gloomy

Job pessimism is especially pronounced among college graduates. The shift probably is because hiring in many white-collar professions has been unusually [See Jobs, A10]



RONALDO BOLANOS Los Angeles Times

WHY UCLA COULD FALL

Angela Dugalic, right, passes to teammate Kiki Rice. UCLA looks primed for a tournament loss, columnist Mirjam Swanson writes. **SPORTS, B10**

Urgency grows amid TSA delays

As disruptions deepen at airports, senators pursue a deal for Homeland Security funding. **NATION, A5**

Weather
Sunny afternoon.
L.A. Basin: 80/57. **B6**

Markets **A11**
Opinion Voices **A12**

Noma offers to talk to protesters

L.A. pop-up restaurant asks them to desist before a meeting. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

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